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Course: Media, Communications and Sociology with Quantitative Methods (BSc)

Department of Media, Culture and Creative Studies

**Algorithmic Curation and the Public Sphere:
Media Platforms, News Exposure and Political Attitudes
Among Young Adults in the United Kingdom**

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Again, thank you, to everybody. Even to the person reading this right now – I hope you can somewhat enjoy the work produced and if not, I will just have to assume you're not a huge fan of numbers (it looks scary, but I promise it's nothing *too* complicated).

- Chris

Abstract

This dissertation asks how social media - specifically X (formerly Twitter) - shapes political polarisation and political attitudes among UK adults aged 18 to 30. Drawing on theories of the public sphere (Habermas, 1989; Fraser, 1990), algorithmic gatekeeping (Gillespie, 2014; Napoli, 2014) and selective exposure (Sunstein, 2009; Pariser, 2011), it tests three working questions about how content exposure, platform use and political efficacy interact. A cross-sectional online survey ($n = 102$) was analysed in SPSS using descriptive, correlational, group-comparison, hierarchical regression and mediation procedures. The results suggest that exposure to political content on X is a meaningful predictor of self-reported polarisation and perceived social-media influence, but that platform use alone does not reshape internal political efficacy or institutional trust, which appear to be anchored more in education and other long-standing civic resources. The findings push back gently against the strongest “echo chamber” claims, suggesting instead that what young UK adults see on X matters more than how long they spend there.

List of Abbreviations

ANOVA - Analysis of Variance

df - Degrees of Freedom

HSD - Honestly Significant Difference (Tukey's post-hoc test)

IV - Independent Variable

DV - Dependent Variable

M - Mean

n - Subsample size

N - Total sample size

NHST - Null-Hypothesis Significance Testing

OLS - Ordinary Least Squares (regression)

r - Pearson correlation coefficient

R^2 - Coefficient of determination (variance explained)

SD - Standard Deviation

SE - Standard Error

SES - Socioeconomic Status

α - Cronbach's alpha (scale reliability) / significance threshold

β - Standardised regression coefficient (beta)

ρ - Spearman rank-order correlation coefficient (rho)

η^2 - Eta-squared (ANOVA effect size)

Chapter 1: Introduction

Over the last decade, broadcast and print outlets have steadily lost ground to digital platforms as a source of political information, particularly among younger audiences in the United Kingdom (Newman et al., 2024). Within this shift, X (formerly Twitter) occupies a distinctive role: its real-time architecture, the visibility it grants to notable political figures, and the ease with which commentary, opinion and breaking news circulate together make it a uniquely concentrated site of political communication, even as its overall audience is smaller than that of Facebook, TikTok or Instagram (Ofcom, 2024).

What sets digital platforms apart from older media is not just speed or scale. It is the ways in which what users encounter is selected and presented. Traditional broadcasters relied on editorial judgement and a shared schedule; social media instead delivers a somewhat endless personalised stream filtered through engagement-optimising algorithms (Gillespie, 2014.) On one hand of the debate, writers such as Sunstein (2001, 2009) and Pariser (2011) argue that algorithmic personalisation produce concepts widely discussed in media and communications literature as “echo chambers” and “filter bubbles” that foster a variety of ideological perspectives, and on the other side, studies may suggest the picture is more probabilistic than deterministic: platform users are exposed to more cross-cutting content than the strong filter-bubble thesis would predict, but the underlying logic of recommendation systems still nudges them toward certain kinds of content (Bakshy, Messing and Adamic, 2015; Dubois and Blank, 2018).

These debates matter because political attitudes - especially polarisation, efficacy and institutional trust - are not just abstract attributes but rather, actively shape people’s personal political patterns and outlook (Iyengar et al., 2019). UK-based research has been slower to address these questions than US-based work, despite the fact that the British political environment, with its parliamentary structure and rather different media ecosystem, may not behave like a typical American case (Chadwick, 2017). The position of 18 to 30 year-olds is particularly interesting with this is cohort boasting high social-media use but comparatively low turnout (Electoral Commission, 2024), and a political socialisation that has unfolded almost entirely alongside the rise of social media.

This dissertation aims to contribute to that conversation by examining the dynamic between political-content exposure on X and a set of political-attitude outcomes among UK adults aged 18 to 30. Three working research questions guide the analysis. First, is exposure to political content on X associated with higher levels of felt polarisation, after controlling for demographic and ideological background? Second, do X-users differ from non-users in their perceived social-media influence, political interest, trust in UK institutions and political efficacy? Third, does political engagement on X translate into a higher likelihood of voting in a future general election, and if so, is that relationship mediated by political efficacy?

The study is also situated in a wider policy moment. The Online Safety Act 2023 has placed algorithmic systems, content moderation and transparency more firmly on the UK regulatory agenda with the rapid evolution of X since its acquisition in 2022 raising more questions about how platform-level decisions feed through into public

discourse. Understanding how young adults experience political communication on these platforms is therefore not just an academic exercise - It feeds into ongoing conversations surrounding how platforms are governed, what counts as harm, and what a proper relationship between social media and democratic participation should look like.

Methodologically, the project uses a quantitative cross-sectional survey design ($n = 102$), analysed in SPSS using descriptive statistics, Pearson and Spearman correlations, t-tests, ANOVA, chi-square tests and hierarchical multiple regression. These results have been represented in a way that reflects what the numbers will actually support, rather than reaching for the most dramatic explanation available.

Exposure to political content on X is the single most consistent predictor of polarisation and perceived influence in this sample, even after controls. The data however does not support the claim that social-media use, in itself, fundamentally shapes young adults' deeper political dispositions: internal political efficacy is more closely linked to education than to anything that happens on the platform, and there is no evidence here that online engagement translates cleanly into offline voting intent. Social media, in short, seems to do less than the loudest accounts suggest, but more than the most sceptical ones allow for.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 The public sphere and its critics

Any discussion of social media's political consequences has to start, at least briefly, with the question of what we expect political communication to *do* in the first place. The dominant framework for thinking about this question in the social sciences can be found in Habermas's (1989) account of the public sphere - the idea, broadly, that democracy depends on the existence of spaces where citizens can encounter each other's views, reason about shared problems, and arrive at considered judgements through deliberation. For Habermas, the eighteenth-century coffee house and the broadsheet newspaper were the historical examples; the worry, in his later work, was that mass media had hollowed these spaces out by turning citizens into audiences and substituting consumption for participation (Habermas, 1989, 2006).

The framework has been criticised from several angles, and these criticisms matter for what follows. Fraser (1990) argued that Habermas's "single" public sphere was always a fiction, since access to it had historically been gated by class, race and gender, and that meaningful political life has in practice always involved a plurality of counter-publics - overlapping, sometimes hostile, often non-deliberative - rather than a unified rational forum. Dahlgren (2005) pushed in a similar direction, suggesting that contemporary political talk online is better understood as a sprawling, uneven ecology of partial publics than as anything approaching the deliberative ideal. What both critiques share is a refusal to take the deliberative model as a neutral yardstick, and that scepticism is worth carrying into the discussion of social media that follows: it is one thing to say that platforms like X fall short of Habermas's standard, but quite another to assume that standard was ever the right one in the first place.

A more constructive framing, and one I find more useful for thinking about a hybrid environment like X, is Chadwick's (2017) notion of a *hybrid media system*. Chadwick's argument is that the old binary between "broadcast" and "online" misses how thoroughly the two have grown into each other: television journalists now break stories from social-media posts, those posts then get re-broadcast back to a mass audience, and the resulting content is in turn responded to, mocked, or amplified by ordinary users in ways that feed back into the next news cycle. Social media, on this account, is not a separate space sitting alongside traditional politics but the connective tissue that runs through and reshapes it. That framing is helpful here because it stops us from treating "X effects" as if they occur in some hermetically sealed digital arena.

2.2 From editors to algorithms: the curation problem

If the question is who decides which political information reaches citizens, the move from a broadcast era to an algorithmic remains consequential. In the broadcast model, the curation work was done by a relatively small number of editors, producers and gatekeepers operating under professional norms (Bennett and Iyengar, 2008); whatever the failings of that system, the decisions it produced were at least susceptible to scrutiny. The algorithmic systems that now dominate platform feeds however work very differently. Pariser (2011) coined the term *filter bubble* to describe the worry that these systems, by optimising for engagement, end up showing each user only the content most likely to keep them on the platform, with the unintended consequence that they may also be insulated from views and information that conflict with their existing preferences.

The strongest version of this concern is outlined by Sunstein (2017), who argues that algorithmic personalisation can produce something close to a closed information loop, in which dissenting views simply fail to appear, and existing political identities are reinforced rather than tested. Sunstein's framing is also the most theoretically grounded in the wider literature, drawing on the deliberative tradition associated with Habermas to argue that personalised feeds systematically undermine the kind of cross-cutting exposure that meaningful deliberation depends on. As I go on to discuss further in the following section

2.3 The echo chamber thesis and its limits

The strongest empirical pushback against the filter-bubble framing has come from a series of large-scale studies of actual user behaviour. Bakshy, Messing and Adamic's (2015) analysis of Facebook data found that while algorithmic curation did reduce exposure to cross-cutting content, the effect was modest compared to the much larger filtering effect produced by users' own choices about whom to follow and whose posts to click on. Dubois and Blank (2018), working with UK survey data, made a related point in which most people use multiple sources of political information, and the proportion of users genuinely trapped inside a single-perspective bubble appears to be small. Guess et al. (2018) reached a similar conclusion for a study carried out in the United States, finding that even partisan users encountered considerable counter-attitudinal content. The pattern across these studies is consistent enough that the strongest versions of the echo-chamber thesis are now widely regarded as overstated.

What is more interesting, for my purposes, is the way the literature has moved on from a simple "do echo chambers exist?" question to a more layered set of arguments about what kinds of exposure matter, and in which directions they push. Bail et al.'s (2018) field experiment is probably the single most discussed study in this area with a project that involved Twitter users who were randomly assigned to follow a bot account that retweeted opposing-perspective content and found that participants in fact did not move toward the centre, as deliberative theory would predict, but instead became more entrenched in their original positions. This finding sits awkwardly with both the filter-bubble framing (which assumes cross-cutting exposure is the cure) and the optimistic deliberative reading (which assumes it is the goal). Cinelli et al. (2021) adds depth to the discussion by showing that the structural properties of different platforms matter - X is more open and confrontational whilst Facebook remains more enclosed and ideologically homogenous.

2.4 Polarisation, efficacy, and the core question

The dependent variables in this study are felt polarisation and political efficacy, and it is only fitting, in order to understand the conceptual framework on which this project is built on, that we define these two highly contested concepts. Polarisation in political science once referred almost exclusively to ideological polarisation - the spreading-apart of voters' policy preferences across a left-right axis (DiMaggio, Evans and Bryson, 1996). That literature has been substantially displaced in recent years by work on affective polarisation, associated most prominently with Iyengar et al. (2019), which argues that the more politically consequential shift has been emotional rather than ideological - voters do not necessarily disagree more sharply about policy, but they have come to dislike, distrust and avoid members of the opposing political camp far more intensely than they used to. This is a useful distinction for a study where the findings are rooted in self-report Likert data, because the items most respondents find easy to answer - about feeling that politics divides people, that the country is split into hostile camps, that compromise is no longer possible - lean towards affective rather than ideological polarisation.

Political efficacy is the other side of the picture. The distinction, originally illustrated by Niemi, Craig and Mattei (1991), is between internal efficacy - the sense that one personally has the knowledge and competence to participate meaningfully in politics - and external efficacy; the sense that the political system is responsive to people like oneself. The two concepts behave quite differently in empirical work. Internal efficacy tends to be strongly predicted by education, socioeconomic status, and political interest (Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995), while external efficacy tracks more closely with institutional trust and with perceived responsiveness of the system to ordinary citizens. Both are theoretically central to democratic participation: people who do not believe they are capable of effective political action, or who do not believe such action would matter, tend not to engage even where opportunities present themselves.

The reason both concepts appear in this study is that the relationship between social media use and democratic engagement is often discussed as if it pulls in a single direction - either platforms are eroding civic capacity, or they are democratising it - when in fact the underlying mechanisms point to different outcomes for different components of engagement. There is reasonable evidence that politically attentive

social-media users score higher on internal efficacy than non-users, because exposure to political content builds familiarity and confidence (Boulianne, 2015); but there is also evidence that exposure to political conflict on platforms can erode external efficacy and trust, because what users see is so often dysfunctional and hostile (Tucker et al., 2018). These are not contradictions so much as parallel processes operating on different components of the efficacy construct, and a study that examines them separately stands a better chance of saying something useful than one that collapses them into a single "engagement" variable.

A final point worth noting is that the bulk of the empirical literature in this area has been conducted in the United States, often using Twitter data drawn from the high-salience period around the 2016 and 2020 elections (Bakshy, Messing and Adamic, 2015; Bail et al., 2018; Guess et al., 2018). British work exists - the Reuters Digital News Reports have been particularly useful for tracking the platforms young UK adults actually use - but the dominant empirical picture is American, and the question as to whether American findings translate to a UK context with a different party system - a less polarised media environment, and a different platform mix is not one the existing literature can fully answer. The present study cannot resolve that question either, but by focusing specifically on UK adults aged 18–30, and on X in particular, it tries to add a small piece of British evidence to a debate that has been disproportionately shaped by American data.

Chapter 3: Methodology

This chapter aims to illustrate the research process utilised in the project. It begins by revisiting the aims of the project, followed by an exploration of the epistemological position adopted, the research design, the sampling strategy, the questionnaire, the procedure, ethical considerations and the mapping for analysis carried out. The chapter concludes with a critical evaluation of the methodology that discusses both what the design does well and the limitations a more developed study would need to address.

3.1 Research Aims and Research Questions

The aim of the dissertation is to examine the extent to which use of X shapes self-reported political polarisation, perceived political influence and political efficacy among UK adults aged 18 to 30. From this aim, three working research questions were constructed - **RQ1:** Is exposure to political content on X associated with higher levels of felt polarisation, after demographic and ideological controls? **RQ2:** Do X-users differ from non-users on a series of political-attitude outcomes (perceived social-media influence, political interest, trust in institutions, internal and external efficacy)? **RQ3:** Does political engagement on X predict future voting intention, and if so, is the relationship mediated by internal political efficacy?

3.2 Epistemological Position

The project bodes a relatively positivist stance, on the grounds that the research questions are concerned with the size and direction of relationships between measurable variables across a population (Bryman, 2016). Whilst the ultimate goal of the study is not to capture the interpretive effect of user experiences on X; that would call for a qualitative or mixed-methods design (May, 2011). The decision to remain within a quantitative framework is one rooted in practicality over breadth, made in

light of the time and resource limitations, rather than a categorical dismissal of interpretivist approaches. A more developed version of this project would benefit from refining the survey findings with a series of interview surveys in order to elaborate on the results presented.

3.3 Research Design

The primary method of data collection was a cross-sectional online survey. Cross-sectional designs are well suited to mapping associations between variables at a single point in time (Bhattacharjee, 2012), and self-completing methods for participants have been shown to reduce social desirability bias with regards to politically rooted questionnaires (Tourangeau and Yan, 2007). The use of cross-sectional designs does not hold itself without fault; on its own, we are unable to establish the cause-then-effect that is required to draw any conclusions in confidence. This is discussed further in the critical evaluation below.

3.4 Sampling and Recruitment

The target population was UK residents aged 18 to 30. A non-probability convenience sample was used with snowball elements throughout recruitment: the survey link was circulated through the researcher's personal networks, university social-media groups and student-oriented WhatsApp channels, and respondents were invited to share the survey with their fellow peers. Eligibility was restricted to UK-resident adults aged 18 to 30 with a total of 102 valid responses obtained over a three-week data collection window. Although convenience sampling is a widely used method in undergraduate dissertation research, it poses a tendency to produce samples that over-represent younger, more highly educated and more digitally engaged respondents (Bryman, 2016), and the present sample displays this exact statistic bias. The subsequent implications are addressed directly in the critical evaluation and again in Chapter 5.

3.5 Survey Structure

The survey consisted of twenty-seven items grouped into four sections. Section A captures demographic and background variables: age band, country of residence, gender, education, employment status, ethnicity and self-placed political orientation. Section B covered social media use variables: frequency of use, daily time on the platform, exposure to political content and a multi-select engagement question (like, share, comment, post original content, follow accounts). Section C captured political attitudes via a five-point Likert series of questions, including: felt polarisation, trust in UK institutions, perceived social-media influence and three composite variables - internal political efficacy, external political efficacy and political interest -each measured by three items adapted from established scales (Niemi, Craig and Mattei, 1991; Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995). Section D covered voting behaviour: reported turnout at the last general election and self-rated likelihood of voting at the next.

3.6 Procedure

The survey was hosted on Qualtrics and remained open for three weeks. The landing page presented the participant with an information sheet and required respondents to provide informed consent before they could proceed.

3.7 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained from the City, St Georges University of London Department of Media, Culture and Creative Studies Ethics Committee. Consent was obtained through a tick-box statement on the landing page with participation prefaced as voluntary and withdrawal permitted at any point prior to submission without explanation, and no personally identifying information was collected. Data was stored on a personal hard drive protected through two factor authentication into the researcher's account. Because politics can be a sensitive topic, the survey avoided emotionally loaded wording wherever possible.

3.8 Data Analysis

Data was exported from Qualtrics into an excel file which was then converted into a .sav file in SPSS - the format utilized for databases in IBM. Likert items were treated as interval for the purpose of parametric analysis, in line with industry standard practice in political-attitude research (Norman, 2010). Composite scales for internal efficacy, external efficacy and political interest were computed as the mean of their subsequent items with Cronbach's alpha used to assess internal consistency (how closely the items within the dataset are related). The analysis plan includes descriptive statistics; Pearson and Spearman correlations, Unequal Variance t-tests, one-way ANOVA, Pearson chi-square, hierarchical multiple regression, with demographical controls from section 1 of the survey and media variables from section 2.

3.9 Critical Evaluation of the Methodology

When curating a research project's methodology, it is important to gain a profound understanding of the strengths and shortcomings of the design. Utilising hierarchical regression rather than relying on senseless correlations alone means the social-media variables are able to be tested for their unique contribution once demographics and ideology have been accounted for. The composite scales for efficacy and interest, even where reliability was modest, are still preferable to single-item reductionist questions and allow internal consistency to be examined against the items that comprise the composite scales (DeVellis, 2017).

Whilst the research design boasts a variety of strengths, it is important to acknowledge paralleled weaknesses. Most notably, the sample size remains considerably small for a research question of the given magnitude with the sample population itself skewing towards a young, female, white and university educated population. This matters particularly for the more counter-intuitive findings, such as the negative coefficient on X-use frequency in the polarisation model which would inherently benefit from a replication of the analysis with a larger, more balanced sample size before any definitive conclusions can be drawn.

The cross-sectional design bodes another obvious constraint - even where associations remain strong, the data cannot speak to definitive direction: it is within the realm of

possibility that already-polarised respondents seek out political content on X as it is that exposure to that content that inherently drives polarisation. Self-report is a related issue. Self-reported platform usage estimates in particular are often overestimated relative to application usage data (Parry et al., 2021).

The reliabilities for internal efficacy ($\alpha = .53$) and political interest ($\alpha = .48$) were modest, and the external-efficacy items did not cohere as a scale at all ($\alpha = .05$). Some of that is due to small size of the sample, but some of it reflects a wider problem with trying to capture political attitudes through condensed scales. The decision to focus exclusively on X is notable as it excludes platforms with very different content ecosystems, particularly TikTok and Instagram, both of which are arguably more central to the political information consumption habits of the younger end of the 18–30 age band (Newman et al., 2024). The findings here should therefore be read as platform-specific rather than as a general claim about "social media".

I believe it is important to note as well that I, Myself, the primary researcher is a young UK social-media user - sitting inside the population I am studying, inevitably shaping both the questions I choose to ask and the ways in which I have interpreted the answers. I have tried to mitigate this by drawing on established scale items rather than wording my own, and reporting null and counter-theoretical findings rather than only those that fit my hypotheses (May, 2011). But the wider interpretations presented in the following sections should be read with that personal positioning in mind.

Chapter 4: Results

4.1 Sample Description

A total of 102 valid responses were obtained. As expected, the sample skews towards younger and university-educated respondents, reflecting the aforementioned convenience-recruitment strategy described in Chapter 3. Just over half were aged 18–20 (52.9%), with 21.6% aged 21–23, 14.7% aged 24–26 and 10.8% aged 27–30. The sample was predominantly comprised of residents in England (78.4%), followed by smaller proportions in Scotland (9.8%), Wales (5.9%), Northern Ireland (2.9%) and other locations (2.9%). Females comprised 52.9% of the sample, males 39.2%, with a small minority identifying as non-binary or preferred not to say. Educationally, 56.9% held an undergraduate degree, 19.6% A-levels, 13.7% a postgraduate qualification and 6.9% GCSEs, and 54.9% were, as expected, students. Politically, 22.5% placed themselves at the centre, with comparable proportions at the left (20.6%), centre-right (17.6%) and centre-left (16.7%); 7.8% identified as right-wing and 14.7% declined to disclose.

Self-reported X use was widespread. Just under two-thirds of respondents (64.7%) used the platform, of whom 17.6% logged in multiple times a day and a further 14.7% once a day. Time on platform was concentrated in the 10–60-minute range, and exposure to political content among users was modal at "Sometimes" (19.6%) and "Often" (20.6%).

4.2 Scale Reliability

Cronbach's alpha was computed for the three composite variables. Internal political efficacy (Q15–Q17, $k = 3$) achieved $\alpha = .53$, political interest (Q9–Q11) $\alpha = .48$, and

external political efficacy (Q18–Q20) $\alpha = .05$. The first two fall below the conventional .70 threshold (Nunnally, 1978) but are consistent with the difficulties of constructing short political-attitude scales in small samples (Niemi, Craig and Mattei, 1991). Further on in reporting, the three comprising items for external efficacy will be reported on individually rather than as a scale for the fact that the composite variable simply failed to cohere with the other data found in the set ($\alpha = .05$).

4.3 Descriptive Statistics

Mean responses on the five-point Likert items clustered around the middle of the scale, with no item displaying floor or ceiling effects. Respondents felt moderately polarised ($M = 2.86$, $SD = 1.05$), reported moderate trust in UK institutions ($M = 2.57$, $SD = 1.18$), and rated the influence of social media on their own political views slightly below the midpoint ($M = 2.68$, $SD = 1.24$). Internal-efficacy items were comparatively high (composite $M = 3.66$, $SD = 0.78$), whilst external efficacy was lower (composite $M = 2.81$, $SD = 0.62$). Among self-identified X-users, mean exposure to political content was 3.24 ($SD = 1.18$) and mean political engagement was 3.26 ($SD = 1.04$). Future-vote likelihood averaged 3.05 ($SD = 1.11$) on the same five-point scale, indicates that those eligible to vote are neutral to likely to vote in the next election.

Table 1. Descriptives for Key Likert Composites and Single Items

Variable	n	M	SD	Range
Political interest (Q9–Q11)	102	3.16	0.83	1.7–5.0
Trust in UK institutions (Q12)	102	2.57	1.18	1–5
Felt polarisation (Q13)	102	2.86	1.05	1–5
Social-media influence (Q14)	99	2.68	1.24	1–5
Internal efficacy (Q15–Q17)	102	3.66	0.78	2.0–5.0
External efficacy (Q18–Q20)	102	2.81	0.62	1.0–4.3
Political-content exposure (X)	66	3.24	1.18	1–5
Political-content engagement (X)	66	3.26	1.04	2–5
Time on X per day (1–5)	66	2.70	1.21	1–5
Future-vote likelihood (1–5)	102	3.05	1.11	1–5

Note. X users only variables computed for the $n = 66$ X-users.

4.4 Bivariate Correlations

Pearson correlations were computed to test the hypothesised associations between platform exposure and political outcomes. Amongst X-users - exposure to political content was significantly and positively associated with polarisation, $r(64) = +.39$, $p = .001$; with perceived social-media influence on respondents' own political views, $r(62) = +.35$, $p = .005$; and with general political interest, $r(64) = +.40$, $p = .001$. Daily time on X showed weaker but still positive associations with both felt polarisation, $r(64) = +.26$, $p = .039$, and trust in UK institutions, $r(64) = +.26$, $p = .037$. The latter result

runs against the dominant theoretical expectation (Tucker et al., 2018) and is taken up properly in Chapter 5.

Frequency of X use was unrelated to political interest, $r(100) = +.09$, $p = .391$, and political-content engagement showed only weak, non-significant correlations with polarisation and political interest. Education was strongly and positively correlated with internal political efficacy, $r(97) = +.52$, $p < .001$ - the single largest bivariate effect in the dataset - whilst extreme ideological positioning was unrelated to polarisation, $r(85) = +.17$, $p = .122$. Spearman rank-order correlations produced a very similar pattern ($\rho = +.40$, $p = .001$ for exposure–polarisation; $\rho = +.42$, $p < .001$ for exposure–interest), suggesting that the Pearson estimates were not affected by the rigid nature of the Likert scales (see table below for Pearson values).

Table 2. Selected Pearson Correlations

Pair	r	p	n	Sig.
Political-content exposure × Felt polarisation	+.39	.001	66	**
Political-content exposure × Social-media influence	+.35	.005	64	**
Political-content exposure × Political interest	+.40	.001	66	**
Time on X × Felt polarisation	+.26	.039	66	*
Time on X × Trust in institutions	+.26	.037	66	*
Political-content engagement × Polarisation	+.14	.280	66	N/A
Education × Internal efficacy	+.52	<.001	99	***
Political interest × Internal efficacy	+.24	.014	102	*
Polarisation × Trust in institutions	.00	.998	102	N/A

Note. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

4.5 Group Comparisons

4.5.1 X-users versus non-users

The Independent-samples Welch t-tests indicated that X-users ($n = 66$) reported significantly higher levels of felt polarisation ($M = 3.18$, $SD = 0.96$) than non-users ($M = 2.28$, $SD = 0.97$), $t(74.1) = 4.57$, $p < .001$, with a large effect size, $d = 0.94$ in accordance with conventional benchmarks (Cohen, 1988). The pattern becomes ever more noticeable for perceived social-media influence: X-users ($M = 3.27$, $SD = 1.04$) scored much higher than non-users ($M = 1.60$, $SD = 0.65$), $t(88.1) = 9.02$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.74$. By contrast, the two groups did not differ on trust in institutions, on internal efficacy, $t(77.4) = 0.10$, $p = .917$, $d = 0.02$ or on external efficacy, $t(72.6) = 0.04$, $p = .969$, $d = 0.01$. Political interest was marginally higher amongst X-users, $t(72.2) = 1.84$, $p = .070$, $d = 0.38$, but the difference did not meet conventional significance thresholds ($p \leq 0.05$).

4.5.2 Differences by political orientation

One-way ANOVA's identified a significant effect of self-positioned political orientation on: felt polarisation, $F(5, 96) = 4.49$, $p = .001$, $\eta^2 = .19$, perceived social-media influence, $F(5, 93) = 2.53$, $p = .034$, $\eta^2 = .12$, and political interest, $F(5, 96) = 2.36$, $p = .045$, $\eta^2 = .11$. When analysing the average polarisation score for each ideological group, left-wingers and right-wingers came out highest and centrists lowest - a pattern that aligns with what affective-polarisation theory predicts (Iyengar et al., (2019).

4.5.3 Differences by education

Education had a substantively large effect on internal political efficacy, $F(4, 97) = 9.86$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .29$, with respondents holding postgraduate qualifications scoring the highest. Education also predicted external efficacy, $F(4, 97) = 4.23$, $p = .004$, $\eta^2 = .15$ - In contrast - political interest, $F(4, 97) = 0.99$, $p = .416$, and felt polarisation, $F(4, 97) = 0.65$, $p = .632$, did not differ across educational categories.

4.6 Categorical Associations

A Pearson chi-square test of independence indicated a significant association between X-use and self-reported political orientation, $\chi^2(5, N = 102) = 12.23$, $p = .032$, $\phi = .35$. There was no significant association between X-use and reported voting at the last general election, $\chi^2(2, N = 98) = 1.18$, $p = .559$, nor between education and voting, $\chi^2(8, N = 98) = 9.68$, $p = .287$.

4.7 Multivariate Predictors of Polarisation, Influence, Efficacy and Trust

Four hierarchical multiple regressions were run. In each, demographic and ideological controls were entered at Block 1 (age, gender, education, political orientation, and, where relevant -ideological positioning/extremity); social-media variables were entered at Block 2 (time on X, frequency, exposure to political content and engagement). Results are summarised in Table 3 below.

Table 3. Hierarchical Regression Summary

Outcome (sample)	Block 1 R ²	Block 2 R ²	ΔR^2 (p)	Strongest predictor (β , p)
A. Polarisation (X-users, n = 57)	.06	.38	.32 (<.001)	Pol-content exposure ($\beta = +.47$, $p < .001$)
B. SM influence (X-users, n = 55)	.12	.31	.20 (.020)	Pol-content exposure ($\beta = +.35$, $p = .012$)
C. Internal efficacy (n = 82 / 55)	.32	.29	ns	Education ($\beta = +.54$, $p < .001$)
D. Trust in institutions (n = 82 / 57)	.02	.15	ns	Time on X ($\beta = +.29$, $p = .044$)

Note. Block 1 = demographic and ideological controls; Block 2 adds X-platform usage variables. Sample sizes vary because of listwise deletion of missing values on platform items. ns = not significant.

Model A (polarisation) was the strongest of the four. Demographics alone did not predict polarisation, $R^2 = .06$, $F(4, 52) = 0.77$, $p = .554$. Adding the platform block raised R^2 to .38, an increase of $(\text{Change})R^2 = .32$, $(\text{Change})F(4, 48) = 6.24$, $p < .001$. Within the full model, exposure to political content was most notably the strongest predictor, $\beta = +.47$, $p < .001$. Frequency of X use gained a negative coefficient once exposure was held constant, $\beta = -.30$, $p = .020$, suggesting that once exposure is accounted for, raw screen time on its own no longer becomes a correlative factor to polarisation.

Model B (perceived social-media influence, X-users only) showed a similar increase from demographics, $R^2 = .12$, to the full platform model, $R^2 = .31$, $\Delta R^2 = .20$, $p = .020$. Political-content exposure was again the strongest predictor, $\beta = +.35$, $p = .012$, alongside a negative effect of self-placed orientation, $\beta = -.34$, $p = .015$, with left-leaning respondents perceiving more influence than right-leaning ones. Model C (internal efficacy) was carried almost entirely by education, which was significant in Block 1 ($\beta = +.54$, $p < .001$) and remained the dominant predictor in Block 2 ($\beta = +.47$, $p = .001$). Model D (trust in institutions) was the weakest of the four - only time on X reached statistical significance, $\beta = +.29$, $p = .044$.

4.8 Summary of Findings

Two substantive findings emerge from Chapter 4.

1. Exposure to political content on X is the dominant driver of both felt polarisation and perceived social-media influence in this sample, and it survives adjustment for age, gender, education and political orientation.
2. Education - not platform exposure - is the principal correlate of internal political efficacy in this sample.

Chapter 5: Discussion

5.1 The Research Question

This study asks to what extent social media (specifically X) shapes political polarisation and political attitudes among UK adults aged 18 to 30. The findings suggest the answer is “significantly, but selectively”. Exposure to political content was a notable predictor of polarisation and perceived influence with frequency of use, time on platform and engagement behaviours proving comparatively weak once content exposure was controlled for. This points to a content-driven rather than a dose-driven picture: what young UK adults encounter on X seems to matter more than how long they spend there.

5.2 Findings in Light of the Literature

The strong association between political-content exposure and perceived polarisation ($r = +.39$ at the bivariate level, $\beta = +.47$ in the full multivariate model) is highly consistent with the wider literature regarding polarisation (Iyengar et al., 2019; Cinelli

et al., 2021). The magnitude, however, is notably smaller than the deterministic claims often made in publications surrounding “echo chambers” and aligns more closely with lesser acknowledged works that illustrate; platform exposure tends to nudge rather than completely inform attitudes (Bail et al., 2018).

A pattern that denies interaction time as a leading causal factor – one that once exposure is held constant, raw frequency and time on X carry no additional positive effect on polarisation (and in Model A even a small negative coefficient on frequency) - reinforcing the view that algorithmic and self-selected content is the key ingredient, not screen time itself (Tucker et al., 2018).

A second result, that X-users perceive themselves as substantially more influenced by social media than non-users ($d = 1.74$), is consistent with the wider literature on perceived media influence, including Davison’s (1983) third-person effect and its more recent first-person variants. It may also reflect a degree of social desire amongst non-users who may wish to characterise their own opinions as autonomous.

The strongest individual finding in the dataset is the relationship between education and internal political efficacy ($\beta = +.54$, $p < .001$), which sits comfortably alongside longstanding accounts of political participation (Verba, Schlozman and Brady, 1995) and recent UK-focused work on political knowledge (Sturgis et al., 2018). Education survived every social-media variable in Model C suggesting that, at least in this sample, platform exposure does not substitute for, or meaningfully add to, the efficacy-building effects that education has demonstrated within this particular age band.

5.3 Null and Counter-Theoretical Findings

In light of positive findings, it is important that we draw attention to their parallels and examine two results that ran against expected patterns.

1. The efficacy and political-interest scales all returned sub-optimal reliabilities, with external efficacy ($\alpha = .05$) failing to cohere as a scale at all. Part of this is due to a small sample size. Substantive interpretations of said results should therefore be approached with caution.
2. Time on X was positively associated with trust in UK institutions, $r = +.26$, $p = .037$, which is the opposite direction to the most common theoretical prediction. One plausible explanation is that hyper consumers of platforms such as X in this sample include a subgroup who consume mainstream-media content and verified journalism alongside political commentary, which can enhance rather than erode institutional trust (Newman et al., 2024).

5.4 Theoretical Implications

When examined holistically, the results may act as a source for discourse against dominating “echo chamber” and “filter bubble” claims. They are more consistent with what Bail (2021) describes as the “social-media prism” - a platform that distorts users’ sense of the political environment without necessarily converting them to a different ideological position - and with Chadwick’s (2017) hybrid media system, in which platform effects interact with politics that occur away from the internet rather than displacing them. They also nudge the public-sphere literature in a particular direction:

the issue is less whether platforms have replaced the deliberative ideal Habermas (1989) describes - they clearly have not - and more about how the residual fragments of that ideal coexist and interact with the engagement-driven frameworks, similar to that of which Gillespie (2014) and Beer (2017) identify.

5.5 Limitations

Before any conclusions may be drawn from this particular study it is important to note a few limitations. First, the sample is a non-probability convenience sample of $n = 102$, predominantly young, English, female and university-educated; generalisation to all UK adults aged 18–30 is therefore limited and secondly, all measures are self-report and the design is cross-sectional, so causal claims (in either direction) cannot be made.

Chapter 6: Conclusion

This dissertation set out to investigate how social media platforms (specifically X) shape political polarisation and political attitudes among UK adults aged 18 to 30. Drawing on theories of the public sphere, algorithmic gatekeeping and selective exposure, it tested three working questions through a quantitative survey of 102 UK respondents and a series of bivariate and multivariate analyses.

The key finding is that exposure to political content on X is consistently and robustly associated with both polarisation and perceived social-media influence amongst young UK adults, even after controlling for age, gender, education and political orientation. This effect is content-driven rather than dose-driven: time on platform and raw frequency of use do not, on their own, exacerbate polarisation once content exposure is held constant. In that sense, the data support claims of the algorithmic-gatekeeping argument pioneered by Gillespie (2014) and Beer (2017) - platforms shape political experience, but they do so through what they show users rather than by sheer volume of exposure.

At the same time, the study finds little support for the strongest claims of the echo-chamber and filter-bubble literatures (Sunstein, 2009; Pariser, 2011). Where exposure does matter, the effect size is moderate rather than substantive. Internal political efficacy is rooted heavily in education over any aspect of platform use, and there is no evidence here that political engagement on X translates into a higher likelihood of voting via a means of higher efficacy, both internal and external.

Three contributions follow the conclusion of this study. Theoretically, the study adds to a growing UK-based evidence base showing that platform effects on political attitudes are real but limited, and that the precise causal mechanism is selective content exposure rather than time on platform and Practically, the findings have some bearing on current regulatory debates: *if* the active ingredient is content exposure rather than total platform time, then policy interventions framed around screen-time reduction are unlikely to address the key political-attitude effects, whereas interventions aimed at transparency in algorithmic curation and platforms - namely the direction outlined by the Online Safety Act 2023 - may be better targeted.

Several points of improvement for future research follow from the limitations identified in Chapter 3. A larger, probability-based sample, ideally one drawn from an established UK study, would allow these relationships to be tested more robustly and would address the demographic skew of the present sample alongside Comparative work across X, TikTok and Instagram would test how far the present findings generalise across platforms with very different content ecosystem (Newman et al., 2024). And a mixed-methods extension that combined survey results with in-depth interviews would help explain the puzzling positive association between time on X and institutional trust, which deserves more interpretive attention than a single quantitative study can give it.

What the dissertation suggests, more than anything, is that the relationship between social media and politics is messier than either side of the debate tends to allow - neither the wholesale erosion of democratic life that its critics describe, nor the harmless background hum its defenders are willing to settle for. What it is, with the evidence here, is conditional, selective and content-specific - and that is a more useful place for sociological research and policy thinking to start from than either of the extreme positions offer.

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APPENDIX A - SYNTAX

*Import transformed dataset from local drive.

```
GET FILE='/Users/christianmclernon/Downloads/Dissertation_Survey_ResultsMain.sav'.
```

```
DATASET NAME survey2 WINDOW=FRONT.
```

* Internal political efficacy (Q15-Q17).

RELIABILITY

```
/VARIABLES=Q15_QualifiedToParticipate Q16_UnderstandPoliticalIssues  
Q17_ConfidentDiscussing
```

```
/SCALE('Internal Efficacy')=ALL
```

* Cronbach's Alpha (Reliability) – Measures reliability of all composite variables, very commonly used in Likert questions.

```
/MODEL=ALPHA
```

```
/STATISTICS=DESCRIPTIVE SCALE CORR
```

```
/SUMMARY=TOTAL.
```

* External political efficacy (Q18-Q20).

RELIABILITY

```
/VARIABLES=Q18_PeopleLikeMeHaveSay Q19_PoliticiansCare  
Q20_ParticipationMakesDifference
```

```
/SCALE('External Efficacy')=ALL
```

```
/MODEL=ALPHA
```

```
/STATISTICS=DESCRIPTIVE SCALE CORR
```

```
/SUMMARY=TOTAL.
```

* Political interest composite (Q9-Q11).

RELIABILITY

/VARIABLES=Q9_PoliticsImportant Q10_StrongPoliticalBeliefs Q11_DiscussPolitics

/SCALE('Political Interest')=ALL

/MODEL=ALPHA

/SUMMARY=TOTAL.

* Descriptive Statistics.

FREQUENCIES VARIABLES=Q1_Age Q2_Country Q3_UsesX Q21_VotedLastGE

Q22_FutureVoteLikelihood Q23_Gender Q24_Education Q25_Employment

Q26_Ethnicity Q27_PoliticalOrientation

/ORDER=ANALYSIS.

FREQUENCIES VARIABLES=Q4_FrequencyX Q5_TimeOnX_perDay

Q6_PoliticalContent_Exposure Q7_PoliticalContent_Engagement

/ORDER=ANALYSIS.

* Q8 - frequency of each engagement type (X-users only).

TEMPORARY.

SELECT IF (X_user = 1).

DESCRIPTIVES VARIABLES=Q8_Like Q8_Share Q8_Comment Q8_PostOriginal

Q8_FollowAccounts Q8_NoneOfAbove

/STATISTICS=MEAN SUM.

* Likert + composite descriptives.

DESCRIPTIVES VARIABLES=Q9_PoliticsImportant Q10_StrongPoliticalBeliefs

Q11_DiscussPolitics Q12_TrustUKInstitutions Q13_FeelPolarised

Q14_SocialMediaInfluence Q15_QualifiedToParticipate

Q16_UnderstandPoliticalIssues Q17_ConfidentDiscussing

Q18_PeopleLikeMeHaveSay Q19_PoliticiansCare Q20_ParticipationMakesDifference

InternalEff ExternalEff PolInterest

/STATISTICS=MEAN STDDEV MIN MAX SKEWNESS KURTOSIS.

DESCRIPTIVES VARIABLES=X_freq X_time X_polexposure X_polengagement

/STATISTICS=MEAN STDDEV MIN MAX.

* Bivariate Correlations.

* Pearson — interval-like Likerts and composites.

CORRELATIONS

/VARIABLES=X_freq X_time X_polexposure X_polengagement

Polarised SMInfluence TrustInst PolInterest

InternalEff ExternalEff

/PRINT=TWOTAIL NOSIG

/STATISTICS DESCRIPTIVES

/MISSING=PAIRWISE.

* Spearman — non-parametric robustness check (recommended for ordinal).

NONPAR CORR

/VARIABLES=X_freq X_time X_polexposure X_polengagement

Polarised SMInfluence TrustInst PolInterest

InternalEff ExternalEff PolOrient PolExtremity

/PRINT=SPEARMAN TWOTAIL NOSIG

/MISSING=PAIRWISE.

*Group Comparisons.

* Independent-samples t-tests: X-users vs non-users.

T-TEST GROUPS=X_user(0 1)

/MISSING=ANALYSIS

/VARIABLES=PolInterest Polarised TrustInst InternalEff ExternalEff

SMInfluence FutureVote

/CRITERIA=CI(.95).

* ANOVA: political orientation × outcomes.

ONEWAY Polarised SMInfluence TrustInst InternalEff ExternalEff

PolInterest BY PolOrient

/STATISTICS DESCRIPTIVES HOMOGENEITY

*Further analysis for which groups differ from which using TUKEY.

/POSTHOC=TUKEY ALPHA(.05).

* ANOVA: education × outcomes.

ONEWAY InternalEff PolInterest Polarised BY Education_n

/STATISTICS DESCRIPTIVES HOMOGENEITY

/POSTHOC=TUKEY ALPHA(.05).

* ANOVA: age × outcomes.

ONEWAY Polarised SMInfluence PolInterest BY Age_n

/STATISTICS DESCRIPTIVES.

/POSTHOC=TUKEY ALPHA(.05).

*Chi Square Tests.

CROSSTABS

/TABLES=X_user BY Voted

PolOrient BY Voted

Gender_n BY Voted

Education_n BY Voted

/STATISTICS=CHISQ PHI

/CELLS=COUNT ROW COLUMN

/COUNT ROUND CELL.

* Hierarchical regression.

* Each model uses two blocks:

* Block 1: demographic / control variables.

* Block 2: social-media exposure & engagement variables.

* The R-squared change at Block 2 quantifies the unique contribution of

* Social-media variables after controlling for demographics.

* Model A: Predicting self-reported polarisation (Q13).

REGRESSION

/DESCRIPTIVES MEAN STDDEV CORR SIG N

/MISSING LISTWISE

/STATISTICS COEFF OUTS R ANOVA CHANGE COLLIN TOL ZPP

/CRITERIA=PIN(.05) POUT(.10)

/NOORIGIN

/DEPENDENT Polarised

/METHOD=ENTER Age_n Gender_n Education_n PolExtremity

/METHOD=ENTER X_freq X_time X_polexposure X_polengagement

/SCATTERPLOT=(*ZRESID ,*ZPRED)

/RESIDUALS HISTOGRAM(ZRESID) NORMPROB(ZRESID).

* Model B: Predicting perceived social-media influence on views (Q14).

* Subset to X-users only.

TEMPORARY.

SELECT IF (X_user = 1).

REGRESSION

/MISSING LISTWISE

/STATISTICS COEFF OUTS R ANOVA CHANGE COLLIN TOL ZPP

/DEPENDENT SMInfluence

/METHOD=ENTER Age_n Gender_n Education_n PolExtremity

/METHOD=ENTER X_freq X_time X_polexposure X_polengagement.

* Model C: Predicting internal political efficacy (proxy for political understanding).

REGRESSION

/MISSING LISTWISE

/STATISTICS COEFF OUTS R ANOVA CHANGE COLLIN TOL ZPP

/DEPENDENT InternalEff

/METHOD=ENTER Age_n Gender_n Education_n

/METHOD=ENTER X_polexposure X_polengagement Polarised SMInfluence.

* Model D: Predicting trust in institutions.

REGRESSION

/MISSING LISTWISE

/STATISTICS COEFF OUTS R ANOVA CHANGE COLLIN TOL ZPP

/DEPENDENT TrustInst

/METHOD=ENTER Age_n Gender_n Education_n PolExtremity

/METHOD=ENTER X_polexposure X_polengagement.

APPENDIX B – ETHICS FORM APPROVAL

City St George's, University of London

Dear Christian

Reference: ETH2526-1280

Project title: ALGORITHMIC CURATION AND THE PUBLIC SPHERE: X, NEWS EXPOSURE, AND POLITICAL ATTITUDES AMONGST YOUNG ADULTS IN THE UK

Start date: 14 Apr 2026

End date: 11 May 2026

I am writing to you to confirm that the research proposal detailed above has been granted **formal approval** from the Media, Culture & Creative Industries Research **Ethics** Committee. The Committee's response is based on the protocol described in the application **form** and supporting documentation. **Approval** has been given for the submitted application only and the research must be conducted accordingly. You are now free to start recruitment.

The **approval was given with the following conditions:**

- ...
- ...
- ...

Please ensure that you are familiar with [City's Framework for Good Practice in Research](#) and any appropriate Departmental/School guidelines, as well as applicable external relevant policies.

Please note the following:

Project amendments/extension

You will need to submit an amendment or request an extension if you wish to make any of the following changes to your research project:

APPENDIX C – CONSENT FORM (QUALTRICS)

Q1

Welcome to the research study!

We are interested in understanding **Algorithmic Curation, Social media and its relation to Political Polarisation**. For this study, you will be presented with information relevant to Algorithmic Curation, Social media and its relation to Political Polarisation. Then, you will be asked to answer some questions about it. Your responses will be kept completely confidential.

The study should take you around **10 minutes** to complete. Your participation in this research is voluntary. You have the right to withdraw at any point during the study. The Principal Investigator of this study can be contacted at **Christian McLernon (Christian.mclernon@city.ac.uk)**

By clicking the button below, you acknowledge:

- Your participation in the study is voluntary.
- You are 18 years of age.
- You are aware that you may choose to terminate your participation at any time for any reason.

☐ I consent, begin the study

☐ I do not consent, I do not wish to participate

APPENDIX D – INFORMATION SHEET

Information Sheet

REC reference number (ETH2526-1280), 26/02/2026 – Version 1

Title of research: ALGORITHMIC CURATION AND THE PUBLIC SPHERE: X, NEWS EXPOSURE, AND POLITICAL ATTITUDES AMONGST YOUNG ADULTS IN THE UK.

Name of principal investigator/researcher: Christian McLernon

Invitation paragraph

We would like to invite you to take part in a **questionnaire** that forms part of a **undergraduate** research project. Before you decide whether you would like to take part it is important that you understand why the research is being done and what it would involve for you. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Ask us if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information.

What is the purpose of the research?

The purpose of the research proposed aims to investigate correlations and relationships between ever-emerging algorithmic based platforms such as TikTok, Instagram and namely, X and consequent political views; I aim to explore subsequent political attitudes amongst primary demographics for social media use in the UK (18-30). The project draws on multiple sociological theories that help explain contemporary forms of media, marketing/advertising and sociopolitics.

Why have I been invited to take part?

You have volunteered to participate in this study as a result of social media recruitment. Alongside 99 other people, your responses will be utilized to inform the study.

Do I have to take part?

Participation in the project is completely voluntary, and you are free to choose not to complete the survey/questionnaire. You can stop participating at any point during the survey by exiting **Qualtrics**. It is up to you to decide whether to take part or not. If you decide to take part, you are still free to stop participating at any time without giving a reason. Participants can stop completing the survey at any given point with any data inputted onto the platform being erased unless saved for completion at a later date, in such instances, any data provided will be erased and not included in the study. Participants can withdraw their data up to 4 weeks from completion of the survey.

What will happen if I take part?

The nature of the study inherently boasts sensitive with discussions of sociopolitics being the forefront of the investigation. The survey will take anywhere from 10-20 minutes. Questions will include introspective discussions surrounding social media use and subsequent political attitudes. Your personal data and responses will be collected in order to inform the study with only those involved in the research and processing of said information will have access. All identifying information will not be recorded. All data is to be stored securely and destroyed once the study has concluded.

What are the benefits and risks of taking part?

There are no direct benefits to participating in the study, participation however contributes to a wider understanding towards existing knowledge with regards to the relationship between political attitudes and social media use, allowing us to carry out more informed decisions when faced with actions such as parliamentary elections. There are no inherent risks linked to taking part in this particular study.

What will happen to the results?

If the data will be used as part of a dissertation/report/or thesis this should be noted. Publications, including possible future publications as well as the current thesis/report. **If you wish to receive the results of the project, your contact details will also be kept for this purpose or you will be provided with web address to access this.**

Who has reviewed the research project?

This research project (**ETH2526-1280**), **26/02/2026** has been approved by City St George's, University of London by **The Media, Culture and Creative Industries** Research Ethics Committee.

Data privacy statement

City St George's, University of London is the sponsor, and the data controller of this study based in the United Kingdom. This means that we are responsible for looking

after your information and using it properly. The legal basis under which your data will be processed is City St George's public task.

Your rights to access, change or move your information are limited, as we need to manage your information in a specific way in order for the research to be reliable and accurate. To safeguard your rights, we will use the minimum personally identifiable information possible (for further information please see <https://ico.org.uk/for-organisations/uk-gdpr-guidance-and-resources/lawful-basis/a-guide-to-lawful-basis/public-task/>). City St George's will use your name and contact details to contact you about the research study as necessary. **If you wish to receive the results of the study, your contact details will also be kept for this purpose, or you will be provided with a web address.** The only people at City St George's who will have access to your identifiable information will be members of the research team, and, if appropriate, individuals with responsibility for monitoring and auditing at City St George's, including of research projects. There may be occasions when regulatory authorities may access research data in accordance with their statutory powers.

You can find out more about how City St George's handles personal data by visiting <https://www.city.ac.uk/about/governance/policies/data-protection-policy>. You can also read City's general privacy notice by visiting <https://www.city.ac.uk/about/governance/policies/general-privacy-notice> . If you are concerned about how we have processed your personal data, you can contact the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO) directly <https://ico.org.uk/>.

Insurance

City St George's, University London holds insurance policies which apply to this project, subject to the terms and conditions of the policy. If you feel you have been harmed or injured by taking part in this project you may be eligible to claim compensation. This does not affect your legal rights to seek compensation. If you are harmed due to someone's negligence, then you may have grounds for legal action.

What if there is a problem?

If you have any problems, concerns or questions about this project, you should ask to speak to a member of the research team. If you remain unhappy and wish to complain formally, you can do this through the University complaints procedure. To complain about the project, you can write to or email the Secretary to Senate Research Ethics Committee and inform them that the name of the project is ALGORITHMIC CURATION AND THE PUBLIC SPHERE: X, NEWS EXPOSURE, AND POLITICAL ATTITUDES AMONGST YOUNG ADULTS IN THE UK.

Research Governance, Ethics, and Integrity Manager
Research & Innovation Directorate
City St George's, University of London
Northampton Square, London, EC1V 0HB
Email: senaterec@city.ac.uk

Further information and contact details

Contact details of someone who will answer any inquiries about the research (include details of supervisor/s if the researcher is a student). Only City St George's email addresses and phone numbers should be used.

Thank you for taking the time to read this information sheet.

APPENDIX E - QUESTIONNAIRE

Q1. Age

- 18–20
- 21–23
- 24–26
- 27–30
- Prefer not to say

Q2. Country of residence

- England
- Scotland
- Wales
- Northern Ireland
- Other (please specify)

Section 2: Social Media Usage

Q3. Do you use X>

- Yes
- No

(If “No”, skip to political attitudes section)

Q4. How often do you use X?

- Multiple times a day
- Once a day
- Several times a week
- Once a week
- Less than once a week
- Never

Q5. On average, how much time do you spend on X per day?

- Less than 10 minutes
- 10–30 minutes
- 30–60 minutes

- 1–2 hours
- More than 2 hours

Q6. How often do you encounter political content on X?

- Very often
- Often
- Sometimes
- Rarely
- Never

Q7. How often do you actively engage with political content on X? (e.g., liking, sharing, commenting)

- Very often
- Often
- Sometimes
- Rarely
- Never

Q8. What type of political engagement do you participate in? (Select all that apply)

- Like posts
- Share/retweet
- Comment/reply
- Post original political content
- Follow political accounts
- None of the above

Section 3: Political Attitudes (Likert Scale)

(5-point scale for all: Strongly disagree → Strongly agree)

Q9. Politics is important in my daily life

Q10. I feel strongly about my political beliefs

Q11. I regularly discuss politics with others

Q12. I trust political institutions in the UK

Q13. I feel politically polarised compared to others

Q14. Social media has influenced my political views

Section 4: Political Efficacy (Mediator Variable)

(5-point Likert scale)

Internal efficacy:

Q15. I consider myself well-qualified to participate in politics

Q16. I have a good understanding of political issues

Q17. I feel confident discussing politics

External efficacy:

Q18. People like me have a say in what the government does

Q19. Politicians care about what people like me think

Q20. I feel that my political participation can make a difference

Section 5: Political Behaviour

Q21. Did you vote in the most recent UK general election?

- Yes
- No
- Not eligible at the time
- Prefer not to say

Q22. How likely are you to vote in future elections?

- Very likely
 - Likely
 - Neutral
 - Unlikely
 - Very unlikely
-

Section 6: Demographics (Control Variables)

Q23. Gender

- Male
- Female
- Non-binary
- Prefer to self-describe: _____
- Prefer not to say

Q24. Highest level of education completed

- GCSEs or equivalent
- A-levels or equivalent
- Undergraduate degree
- Postgraduate degree

- Other

Q25. Employment status

- Student
- Employed (full-time)
- Employed (part-time)
- Unemployed
- Other

Q26. Ethnicity

- White
- Black
- Asian
- Mixed
- Other
- Prefer not to say

Q27. Political orientation

- Left-wing
- Centre-left
- Centre
- Centre-right
- Right-wing
- Prefer not to say

APPENDIX F – SPSS OUTPUT

The screenshot displays the SPSS Output window with the following content:

Descriptives

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation	Skewness	Kurtosis
	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic	Statistic
Q9: Politics is important in my daily life	100	1	5	2.76	1.264	.099	-.241
Q10: I feel strongly about my political beliefs	101	1	5	3.59	1.133	-.406	-.661
Q11: I regularly discuss politics with others	101	1	5	3.10	1.109	.115	-.716
Q12: I trust political institutions in the UK	102	1	5	2.57	1.182	.420	-.711
Q13: I feel politically polarized compared to others	102	1	5	2.86	1.053	-.051	-.239
Q14: Social media has influenced my political views	99	1	5	2.68	1.244	.024	-.194
Q15: I am well-qualified to participate in politics	99	1	5	3.65	1.053	-.423	-.384
Q16: I have a good understanding of political issues	101	1	5	3.64	1.073	-.184	-.1020
Q17: I feel confident discussing politics	101	2	5	3.67	1.069	-.113	-.1261
Q18: People like me have a say in what government does	102	1	5	2.79	.958	.082	-.157
Q19: Politicians care what people like me think	101	1	5	2.64	1.045	.012	-.820
Q20: My participation can make a difference	101	1	5	2.99	1.136	-.147	-.590
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	102	2.00	5.00	3.6634	.77608	.105	-.239
External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)	102	1.00	4.33	2.8088	.61936	-.059	.239
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	102	1.67	5.00	3.1552	.82762	.147	-.239
Valid N (listwise)	88						

DESCRIPTIVES VARIABLES=X_freq X_time X_polsexposure X_polengagement
/STATISTICS=MEAN STDDEV MIN MAX.

Descriptives

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
Frequency of X use (1-6 ordinal)	102	1.00	6.00	3.0980	2.03684
Daily time on X (1-5 ordinal)	66	1.00	5.00	2.6970	1.21490

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Correlations

		Frequency of X use (1-6 ordinal)	Daily time on X (1-5 ordinal)	Political content exposure on X (1-5)	Political engagement on X (1-5)	Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Social media influence on views (= Q14)	Trust in UK institutions (= Q12)	Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)	Political orientation (1=Left, 5=Right)	Political extremity (distance from centre)
Frequency of X use (1-6 ordinal)	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.123	-.116	-.163	.190	.463**	.135	.089	-.005	.040	-.048	.012
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.324	.355	.192	.056	<.001	.176	.374	.962	.687	.862	.913
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102	87	87
Daily time on X (1-5 ordinal)	Correlation Coefficient	.123	1.000	.052	-.067	.240	.139	.262*	.089	-.001	.071	.024	.071
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.324		.681	.591	.053	.274	.033	.476	.992	.571	.855	.589
N		66	66	66	66	66	64	66	66	66	66	60	60
Political content exposure on X (1-5)	Correlation Coefficient	-.116	.052	1.000	.080	.398***	.324***	-.106	.423***	.229	.001	.220	-.206
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.355	.681		.523	<.001	.009	.398	<.001	.065	.993	.092	.113
N		66	66	66	66	66	64	66	66	66	66	60	60
Political engagement on X (1-5)	Correlation Coefficient	-.163	-.067	.080	1.000	.123	-.012	-.224	.099	-.010	.002	.040	-.070
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.192	.591	.523		.324	.923	.070	.430	.937	.987	.761	.595
N		66	66	66	66	66	64	66	66	66	66	60	60
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Correlation Coefficient	.190	.240	.398***	.123	1.000	.375***	.037	.310**	.120	-.050	.061	.135
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.056	.053	<.001	.324		<.001	.712	.002	.228	.619	.576	.212
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102	87	87
Social media influence on views (= Q14)	Correlation Coefficient	.463***	.324***	.324***	-.012	.375***	1.000	-.085	.224**	.201*	-.042	-.066	-.136
	Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.009	.009	.923	<.001		.404	.026	.046	.677	.551	.217
N		99	64	64	64	99	99	99	99	99	99	84	84
Trust in UK institutions (= Q12)	Correlation Coefficient	.135	.262*	-.106	-.224	.037	-.085	1.000	-.108	.203*	.266**	.099	-.290*
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.176	.033	.398	.070	.712	.404		.279	.041	.007	.362	.006
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102	87	87
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Correlation Coefficient	.089	.089	.423***	.099	.310**	.224*	-.108	1.000	.247*	-.035	-.021	.233*
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.374	.476	<.001	.430	.002	.026	.279		.012	.723	.846	.030
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102	87	87
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	Correlation Coefficient	-.005	-.001	.229	-.010	.120	.203*	.247*	1.000	.263	.190	-.266	
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.962	.992	.065	.937	.218	.046	.041	.012	.008	.079	.013	
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102	87	87
External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)	Correlation Coefficient	.040	.071	.001	.002	-.050	-.042	.266**	-.035	.263**	1.000	.114	-.274*
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.687	.571	.993	.987	.619	.677	.007	.723	.008		.293	.010
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102	87	87
Political orientation (1=Left, 5=Right)	Correlation Coefficient	-.048	.024	.220	.040	.061	-.066	.099	-.021	.190	.114	1.000	-.320**
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.662	.855	.092	.761	.576	.551	.362	.846	.079	.293		.002
N		87	60	60	60	87	84	87	87	87	87	87	87
Political extremity (distance from centre)	Correlation Coefficient	.012	.071	-.206	-.070	.135	-.136	-.290*	.233*	-.266*	-.274*	-.320**	1.000
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.913	.589	.113	.595	.212	.217	.006	.030	.013	.010	.002	
N		87	60	60	60	87	84	87	87	87	87	87	87

is significant at the 0.001 level (2-tailed).
* is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).
** is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

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Correlations

		Frequency of X use (1-6 ordinal)	Daily time on X (1-5 ordinal)	Political content exposure on X (1-5)	Political engagement on X (1-5)	Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Social media influence on views (= Q14)	Trust in UK institutions (= Q12)	Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)
Frequency of X use (1-6 ordinal)	Pearson Correlation	1	.192	-.079	-.209	.168	.456**	.133	.086	-.028	.019
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.122	.529	.093	.092	<.001	.183	.391	.780	.850
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102
Daily time on X (1-5 ordinal)	Pearson Correlation	.192	1	.031	-.059	.255*	.152	.257*	.134	.082	.082
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.122		.807	.638	.039	.230	.037	.285	.995	.512
N		66	66	66	66	66	64	66	66	66	66
Political content exposure on X (1-5)	Pearson Correlation	-.079	.031	1	.049	.390*	.345*	-.073	.395*	.218	.011
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.529	.807		.698	.001	.005	.518	.001	.054	.910
N		66	66	66	66	66	64	66	66	66	66
Political engagement on X (1-5)	Pearson Correlation	-.209	-.059	.049	1	.135	-.045	-.208	.078	.005	.045
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.093	.638	.698		.280	.725	.093	.534	.966	.722
N		66	66	66	66	66	64	66	66	66	66
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Pearson Correlation	.168	.255*	.390*	.135	1	.380***	.000	.328***	.102	-.081
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.092	.039	.001	.280		<.001	.998	<.001	.306	.418
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102
Social media influence on views (= Q14)	Pearson Correlation	.456**	.152	.345*	-.045	.380*	1	-.093	.224*	.182	-.057
	Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.230	.005	.725	<.001		.358	.026	.071	.574
N		99	64	64	64	99	99	99	99	99	99
Trust in UK institutions (= Q12)	Pearson Correlation	.133	.257*	-.073	-.208	.000	-.093	1	-.089	.241*	.251*
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.183	.037	.558	.093	.998	.358		.371	.015	.011
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Pearson Correlation	.086	.134	.395*	.078	.328***	.224*	-.089	1	.243*	-.024
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.391	.285	.001	.534	<.001	.026	.371		.014	.810
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	Pearson Correlation	-.028	.001	.238	.005	.102	.182	.241*	.243*	1	.241*
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.780	.995	.054	.966	.306	.071	.015	.014		.015
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102
External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)	Pearson Correlation	.019	.082	.011	.045	-.081	-.057	.251*	-.024	.241*	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.810	.512	.930	.722	.418	.574	.011	.810	.015	
N		102	66	66	66	102	99	102	102	102	102

***. Correlation at 0.001 (2-tailed).
*. Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).
**. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Pearson Correlations

Highly Positive: (None)

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with adjusted df

	Based on trimmed mean				
External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)	1.022	4	82	.401	
Based on Mean	.297	4	82	.879	
Based on Median	.336	4	82	.853	
Based on Median and with adjusted df	.336	4	72.971	.853	
Based on trimmed mean	.280	4	82	.890	
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	.534	4	82	.711	
Based on Mean	.456	4	82	.768	
Based on Median	.456	4	80.258	.768	
Based on Median and with adjusted df	.456	4	80.258	.768	
Based on trimmed mean	.538	4	82	.709	

ANOVA

		Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Between Groups	6.043	4	1.511	1.632	.174
	Within Groups	75.911	82	.926		
	Total	81.954	86			
Social media influence on views (= Q14)	Between Groups	11.577	4	2.894	2.068	.093
	Within Groups	110.565	79	1.400		
	Total	122.143	83			
Trust in UK institutions (= Q12)	Between Groups	12.062	4	3.016	2.298	.066
	Within Groups	107.616	82	1.312		
	Total	119.678	86			
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	Between Groups	4.793	4	1.198	2.099	.088
	Within Groups	46.813	82	.571		
	Total	51.606	86			
External political efficacy (mean Q18-Q20)	Between Groups	2.652	4	.663	2.030	.098
	Within Groups	26.782	82	.327		
	Total	29.435	86			
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Between Groups	4.437	4	1.109	1.895	.119
	Within Groups	48.014	82	.586		
	Total	52.451	86			

Post Hoc Tests

Multiple Comparisons

Tukey HSD

Dependent Variable	(I) Political orientation (1=Left .. 5=Right)	(J) Political orientation (1=Left .. 5=Right)	Mean Difference (I-J)	Std. Error	Sig.	95% Confidence Interval	
						Lower Bound	Upper Bound
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Left-wing	Centre-left	.54342	.31391	.421	-.3322	1.4190
		Centre	.36439	.29040	.719	-.4457	1.1744
	Centre-left	Centre-right	-.08730	.30905	.999	-.9494	.7748
		Right-wing	-.18452	.39975	.990	-1.2996	.9305
	Centre-right	Left-wing	-.54342	.31391	.421	-1.4190	.3322
		Centre	-.17903	.30774	.977	-1.0374	.6794
	Centre	Centre-right	-.63072	.32540	.306	-1.5384	.2770
		Right-wing	-.72794	.41252	.401	-1.8786	.4227
	Right-wing	Left-wing	-.36439	.29040	.719	-1.1744	.4457
		Centre-left	-.17903	.30774	.977	-.6794	1.0374

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Descriptives

		N	Mean	Std. Deviation	Std. Error	95% Confidence Interval for Mean	Minimum	Maximum
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	CCSEs	7	2.9048	.56811	.21473	2.3793	3.4302	2.00
	A-levels	20	3.1833	.50117	.11206	2.9488	3.4179	2.00
	Undergraduate	58	3.7874	.76713	.10073	3.5856	3.9891	2.00
	Postgraduate	14	4.3571	.46159	.12336	4.0906	4.6237	3.33
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	CCSEs	99	3.6835	.77755	.07815	3.5284	3.8386	2.00
	A-levels	7	2.7143	.65060	.24590	2.1126	3.3160	2.00
	Undergraduate	20	3.2250	.85203	.18952	2.8262	3.6238	2.00
	Postgraduate	58	3.1092	.84728	.11125	2.8864	3.3320	1.67
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	CCSEs	14	3.4286	.76715	.20503	2.9856	3.8715	2.00
	A-levels	99	3.1498	.83009	.08343	2.9843	3.3154	1.67
	Undergraduate	7	3.1429	1.08904	.40406	2.1542	4.1316	1.00
	Postgraduate	14	3.0714	.82874	.22149	2.5929	3.5499	2.00
Total								
		99	2.8788	1.06208	.10674	2.6670	3.0906	1.00

Tests of Homogeneity of Variances

		Levene Statistic	df1	df2	Sig.
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	Based on Mean	4.369	3	95	.006
	Based on Median	3.322	3	95	.023
	Based on Median and with adjusted df	3.322	3	87.349	.023
	Based on trimmed mean	4.375	3	95	.006
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Based on Mean	.907	3	95	.441
	Based on Median	.780	3	95	.508
	Based on Median and with adjusted df	.780	3	94.226	.508
	Based on trimmed mean	.968	3	95	.411
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Based on Mean	1.333	3	95	.268
	Based on Median	1.241	3	95	.299
	Based on Median and with adjusted df	1.241	3	94.261	.299
	Based on trimmed mean	1.532	3	95	.211

ANOVA

		Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.
Internal political efficacy (mean Q15-Q17)	Between Groups	16.227	3	5.409	11.944	<.001
	Within Groups	43.023	95	.453		
	Total	59.250	98			
Political interest (mean Q9-Q11)	Between Groups	2.624	3	.875	1.280	.286
	Within Groups	64.903	95	.683		
	Total	67.527	98			
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)	Between Groups	2.055	3	.685	.600	.617
	Within Groups	108.491	95	1.142		
	Total	110.545	98			

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Output

- Log
- Dataset Name
 - Title
 - Notes
- Warnings
- Log
- Reliability
 - Title
 - Notes
 - Active Dataset
 - Scale: Internal I
 - Title
 - Case Proce
 - Reliability S
 - Item Statist
 - Inter-Item
 - Item-Total
 - Scale Statis
- Log
- Reliability
 - Title
 - Notes
 - Scale: External
 - Title
 - Case Proce
 - Reliability S
 - Item Statist
 - Inter-Item
 - Item-Total
 - Scale Statis
- Log
- Reliability
 - Title
 - Notes
 - Scale: Political I
 - Title
 - Case Proce
 - Reliability S
 - Item Statist
 - Inter-Item
 - Item-Total
 - Scale Statis
- Log
- Frequencies
 - Title
 - Notes
 - Statistics
 - Frequency Tabl
 - Title
 - Q1: Age br
 - Q2: Count
 - Q3: Uses X
 - Q3: Vote
 - Q2: Likeli
 - Q3: Gend
 - Q4: High
 - Q5: Empl
 - Q6: Ethn
 - Q7: Politi
- Log
- Frequencies

Warnings

There are 203 (78.1%) cells (i.e., dependent variable levels by observed combinations of predictor variable values) with zero frequencies.

Case Processing Summary

	N	Marginal Percentage
Self-reported polarisation (= Q13)		
1.00	2	3.4%
2.00	5	8.6%
3.00	29	50.0%
4.00	16	27.8%
5.00	6	10.3%
Valid	58	100.0%
Missing	44	
Total	102	

Model Fitting Information

Model	-2 Log Likelihood	Chi-Square	df	Sig.
Intercept Only	138.875			
Final	120.855	18.019	5	.003

Link function: Logit.

Goodness-of-Fit

	Chi-Square	df	Sig.
Pearson	150.438	199	.996
Deviance	113.688	199	1.000

Link function: Logit.

Pseudo R-Square

Cox and Snell	.267
Nagelkerke	.290
McFadden	.123

Link function: Logit.

Parameter Estimates

	Estimate	Std. Error	Wald	df	Sig.	95% Confidence Interval	
						Lower Bound	Upper Bound
Threshold (Polarised = 1.00)	-1.520	2.357	.416	1	.519	-6.140	3.100
(Polarised = 2.00)	-.109	2.304	.002	1	.962	-4.624	4.407
(Polarised = 3.00)	2.961	2.333	1.611	1	.204	-1.611	7.533
(Polarised = 4.00)	4.583	2.391	4.342	1	.037	.296	9.670
Location Age_n	-.056	.087	.418	1	.518	-.227	.114
Education_n	-.306	.323	.898	1	.343	-.940	.327
PolExtremity	.474	.329	2.075	1	.150	-.171	1.118
X_polexposure	.916	.251	13.859	1	<.001	.443	1.428
X_poleengagement	.272	.246	1.220	1	.269	-.211	.755

Link function: Logit.